

Secondary User Research: How Travelers Manage Budgets & Expenses (for Tripflow)

TL;DR

Most travelers manage trip money with a fragmented mix of manual tools — phone notes, banking apps, receipts, mental math, spreadsheets, and dedicated apps — and the single most durable behavior is a short end-of-day reconciliation, not real-time logging.

The dominant friction is entry speed and effort; when logging takes more than a few seconds, travelers postpone it, forget small cash expenses, and abandon tracking by mid-trip. (TravelSpend itself markets its "Quick Add" feature on the promise of logging "in under 2 seconds, so you never miss a transaction.") [App Store](#)

[Store](#)

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The decision travelers most want supported is "can I afford this next purchase?", which depends on a clear remaining-budget and daily-budget number in their home currency — not detailed analytics. Trail Wallet, road-tested by over 150,000 travelers, built its core screen around exactly this: tapping the daily budget label shows "exactly how much you have left to spend each day." [Appstore](#)

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Key Findings

Evidence strength is labeled **Strong** (recurring across multiple independent sources), **Moderate** (several related sources), or **Weak** (isolated anecdote).

1. Current User Behaviors

Categories built from the evidence, not assumed beforehand:

End-of-day reconciliation (most durable pattern). Strong evidence. Multiple independent sources converge on a five-minute evening review as the method that survives a real trip, precisely because real-time logging "tends to fall apart by Day 3" (FinancialAha, *How to Track Expenses While Traveling*). The ritual is "tied to a natural transition point in the day" — sitting at a cafe or back at the hotel. [FinancialAha!](#)

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Dedicated travel expense apps (TravelSpend, Trail Wallet, Tripcoin, Trabee Pocket). Strong evidence. Widely used by long-term travelers, backpackers, couples, and retirees traveling full time. Valued for automatic multi-currency conversion and offline use — TravelSpend advertises support for 170+ currencies that convert to a home currency "using live exchange rates — or cached rates when offline," and the now-discontinued Trail Wallet offered over 218 local currencies. Note: Trail Wallet, despite being "road tested by over 150,000 travellers" (Voyage Travel Apps), was discontinued in November 2023 and is no longer available — a signal that even beloved tools in this space churn. [App Store + 2](#)

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Spreadsheets (Google Sheets on phone). Strong evidence. Popular with detail-oriented and long-term travelers and couples who need a shared, always-editable ledger. One full-time-traveling couple plans in Google Sheets "because if we're not in the same place we can always keep it up to date" (Her Packing List). The trade-off is that "typing numbers on a small screen while standing on a cobblestone street isn't elegant" (FinancialAha). [Her Packing List](#)

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[financialaha](#)



Phone notes / manual lists. Moderate evidence. Fast capture with no automatic calculation — "you're building a list, not a ledger." [financialaha](#)



Banking / card app monitoring. Moderate evidence. Works for card-heavy trips but fails in cash-heavy regions: "Especially in Asia and Central and South America, you use almost only cash. So you can't look at your bank account here at the end of the day to see exactly what you've spent" (The World Trippers). [The](#)

[World Trippers](#)



Mental estimation & receipts-in-pocket. Moderate evidence. Common fallback; small cash expenses get lumped into a rough daily "misc \$10–15" estimate that's "close enough" (FinancialAha). [FinancialAha!](#)



No tracking / abandonment. Moderate evidence. A recurring endpoint: travelers give up mid-trip when effort outweighs perceived value.

2. Recurring Pain Points

Each: pain point · evidence · strength · likely cause · design implication.

Entry is too slow → postponement → forgotten expenses. Strong. A TravelSpend reviewer (Sarah Maney, App Store) explicitly asked for quick add: "Sometimes while on the go, you just want to add the amount and the title really quickly so you don't forget about it later. Then when you have more time go back and put in all the details." The category-leading app now sells a sub-2-second Quick Add in direct response. Cause: multi-field entry flows (trip → amount → category → currency). Implication: a sub-5-second, amount-first capture path. [apple](#)



[App Store](#)



Small, frequent cash expenses go untracked. Strong. Coffee, tips, and transit tickets are the first to be dropped; the FinancialAha field account describes the plan collapsing "standing in a cafe in Lisbon trying to figure out whether to tip on a 4.50 EUR coffee." Cause: effort-to-value mismatch on tiny amounts. Implication: make micro-expenses trivially fast or batchable. [financialaha](#)



[FinancialAha!](#)



Currency conversion friction & multi-currency trips. Strong. Valued when automatic; painful when manual or across 3+ currencies. A Rick Steves forum user tracking an 8-week, 4-currency trip (USD, EUR, GBP, ISK) praised automatic conversion but hit a wall: the app "won't do this in arrears," so retroactively entered expenses used the wrong rate. [Rick Steves Travel Forum](#)



Cannot backdate / edit entries. Moderate. TravelSpend users flagged that inability to backdate a post-midnight dinner "screws up your budget for the next day" (Technext review). A Tripcoin reviewer noted you sometimes can't change info after submitting and must "delete and re enter info again." [Technext](#)



[Apple App Store](#)



Connectivity dependence. Moderate. Offline capture is a hard requirement in remote areas; currency rates are the main online dependency. Getfinny's tester summary: "If your app requires internet to log a

transaction, you will skip entries and lose accuracy." [getfinny](#)

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Shared/group expenses & "who owes whom." Moderate. A distinct recurring need; personal budgeting apps often lack it, driving users to Splitwise — which surpassed 10 million users in 2025 — as a second app.

Paywalls, bugs, dated UI, lost data. Moderate. Trabee Pocket reviewers report the app "will spontaneously end my trip and I can't figure out how to open it again," features moved "behind a pay wall," "no automatic cloud backup," and a redesigned UI that is "less intuitive and more complications added on each screen."

TravelSpend reviewers report crashes and slow paid-tier support. [Apkgk + 3](#)

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Tracking feels like a chore / "pointless." Moderate. A tracker buyer admitted: "I just wasn't able to keep up with my budget - I felt like it was pointless. So for a month or 2, I gave up on using it." Getfinny's problem framing echoes the pattern: "By mid-trip, you have either given up tracking or you are stress-converting every purchase on Google." [gumroad + 2](#)

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3. Key Contexts and Triggers

At the moment of purchase / paying. Some disciplined users log during the transaction. A Tripadvisor forum user: "I track the budget on my smartphone at the same time my travel partner is taking care of the actual payment, so no time lost... adding the transaction into my smartphone at the exact moment of transaction." This is a ~10-second window. [Tripadvisor](#)

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End of day (most common). Evening reconciliation at a cafe or hotel, tied to a natural daily transition.

Mid-trip checkpoint. A halfway realization triggers behavior change: the fear of "discovering on Day 5 of a 10-day trip that you've already burned through 80% of your budget" pushes travelers to downshift — "skip the fancy restaurant, take public transit instead of taxis" (FinancialAha). [financialaha](#)

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Before a discretionary purchase. Checking whether an upgrade/splurge is affordable ("If you're under budget, you can upgrade something without guilt"). [financialaha](#)

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Planning / pre-trip. Setting total and daily budgets and entering pre-booked big-ticket items — one couple "started recording those expenses that we had not yet incurred but planned (reservations)" on day one (TravelSpend App Store review). [apple](#)

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Post-trip. Reconciling against cards ("exported the data into a spreadsheet... to reconcile all our credit card accounts") and using actual data to make future budgets more accurate. [apple](#)

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4. Information Needs

Essential: Remaining budget (trip and/or day) in home currency; today's spend vs. daily budget; a simple on-track / over-budget signal; instant home-currency value of a local price. This is validated by Trail Wallet's most-used feature — an *adjusted* daily budget that rolls unspent money forward and "shows you exactly how much you have left to spend each day" — and by the class of "daily number" apps (BUDGT, Costari) whose entire value proposition is one glanceable "what can I spend today" figure. [Appstor](#)

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Useful supporting: Category breakdown; percentage spent; multi-day/trend view; spend-by-country; who-owes-whom for groups.

Potentially unnecessary (for the core in-trip decision): Map of spend locations (a TravelSpend advocate calls it "more fun than practical"); granular sub-categories; heavy analytics requiring users to "dig through reports."

5. Workarounds

Google Sheets kept on phone for always-editable, shareable ledgers, with a second column that converts local currency automatically (the "mixed approach").

Screenshotting/photographing receipts to reconcile later instead of logging in the moment ("Don't waste precious travel time juggling receipts at the end of the day. Just take a picture of the receipt for future reference" — Tripadvisor forum). [Tripadvisor](#)

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Running two apps together (a tracker plus Splitwise) to cover budgeting and splitting.

Lumping untracked small cash spend into a single daily "misc" estimate.

Checking the banking/card app as a de facto ledger on card-heavy trips.

Fixing a morning exchange rate for offline conversion during the day.

Adding a workaround inside a workaround — e.g., a Tripcoin user who couldn't itemize their share wrote the amount "in the comments section of the expense" so it exported to a separate column. [Etrip](#)

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6. Design Opportunities (How might we...)

Derived only from patterns the research supports:

How might we make expense recording fast enough (amount-first, details-optional) that travelers don't postpone or abandon it?

How might we make capturing small, frequent cash expenses effortless so they aren't the first thing dropped?

How might we communicate remaining budget (trip + daily) in home currency so it directly answers "can I afford this?" at the point of decision?

How might we make offline capture and automatic currency conversion reliable so connectivity never blocks logging?

How might we support quick correction/backdating so a late or mis-dated entry doesn't distort the daily budget?

How might we surface a mid-trip "you're trending over budget" signal early enough for travelers to adjust while days remain?

How might we lower the felt "chore" of tracking so travelers perceive ongoing value rather than quitting?

Details

Top 5 Behavioral Insights

Real-time logging is aspirational; end-of-day reconciliation is what actually persists. (Strong)

Speed of entry is the make-or-break variable for sustained tracking — the market leader now competes on a "under 2 seconds" quick-add claim. (Strong)

Cash-heavy, multi-currency contexts are where existing methods break down; card/bank apps can't see cash, and manual conversion collapses across 3+ currencies. (Strong)

Travelers track primarily to make in-trip spending decisions, and secondarily to plan future trips — not for accounting precision. (Strong)

Abandonment is a real and common outcome, driven by effort, bugs/paywalls, or loss of perceived value; even a 150,000-user app (Trail Wallet) can disappear entirely. (Moderate)

Top 5 Pain Points

Slow multi-field entry causes postponement and forgotten expenses. (Strong)

Small/frequent cash expenses are the first to be dropped. (Strong)

Currency conversion and multi-currency trips add friction, especially retroactively. (Strong)

Inability to backdate/edit distorts the budget and frustrates users. (Moderate)

Connectivity dependence, plus bugs/paywalls/dated UI/lost data, erode trust and drive churn. (Moderate)

Top 5 Information Needs

Remaining budget (trip and day) in home currency. (Strong)

Today's spend vs. daily budget with a clear on-track/over signal. (Strong)

Instant home-currency value of a local price. (Strong)

Category breakdown / percentage spent. (Moderate)

Who-owes-whom for shared travel. (Moderate)

Top 5 Design Opportunities

Amount-first "quick add" capture.

Prominent remaining/daily budget framed for the affordability decision.

Reliable offline capture + automatic conversion.

Easy edit/backdate.

Early mid-trip over-budget signaling.

Research Implications for Tripflow

Dashboard: Prioritize a single, glanceable answer to "am I on track / can I afford this?" — remaining budget (trip and day) and today's spend vs. daily budget, in the home currency, with a simple color/on-track signal. This mirrors the features travelers actually use most (Trail Wallet's adjusted daily budget; the "daily number" app category). Treat category breakdowns, trends, and maps as secondary. Add a mid-trip trajectory cue so users can course-correct before the "80% gone on Day 5" moment. Because Tripflow is a *web* app, invest in making this dashboard fast to reach and readable on a phone browser, since the competitive benchmark is native-app glanceability.

Trip Creation: Let users set both a total and a daily budget — and ideally derive one from the other given trip length, a feature TravelSpend users have explicitly requested ("put in a daily budget and have the app calculate the budget for the trip based on the length"). Let users choose a home currency and enter pre-booked big-ticket items (accommodation, flights) up front, including the ability to spread a single cost across multiple days. Keep setup lightweight so it never becomes a barrier to starting. [App Store](#)

Expense Recording: Optimize ruthlessly for speed — amount-first entry with optional details, smart defaults for currency/category, offline-first capture, and easy edit/backdate. This is the highest-leverage surface because entry friction is the primary driver of postponement and abandonment. A "capture the amount now, categorize later" flow directly addresses the most-requested and most-abandoned behavior.

Recommendations

Staged and concrete, with thresholds that would change them:

Make expense entry the design centerpiece (do this first). Target: a returning user logs a typical expense in under ~5 seconds / ≤ 2 taps plus a number. If usability testing shows entry consistently taking longer, treat it as a release blocker — this single metric predicts whether tracking survives past Day 3.

Design the Dashboard around one decision. Lead with remaining and daily budget in home currency plus an on-track/over signal. Threshold to reconsider: if test users can't answer "can I afford a \$40 dinner tonight?" within a few seconds of opening the app, strip the dashboard down further before adding any analytics.

Make offline capture + automatic currency conversion non-negotiable for any international scope; allow a manually fixed daily rate as an offline fallback. If the initial target segment is strictly domestic single-currency travel, this can be deprioritized — but the evidence says international/multi-currency is where the pain (and differentiation) concentrates.

Build in edit/backdate and a lightweight "quick capture now, categorize later" flow to break the postponement → forgetting → abandonment chain. Benchmark: no user should ever have to delete-and-re-enter to fix an expense.

Defer analytics-heavy features (spend maps, deep sub-categories) until the core capture + at-a-glance-budget loop tests well. Add group/split functionality only if the target segment includes group travelers — it is a distinct need frequently offloaded to a separate app (Splitwise, 10M+ users), so building it half-heartedly adds complexity without winning those users.

Caveats

Reddit thread-level evidence could not be directly verified. Despite targeted searching, specific [r/solotravel](#), [r/travel](#), and [r/longtermtravel](#) permalinks did not surface through the available tools, and a dedicated sub-agent could not retrieve them either. Tier-1 behavioral evidence therefore rests on app-store reviews (TravelSpend, Trabee Pocket, Tripcoin — including 1–3★ complaints), reputable travel forums (Rick Steves, Tripadvisor), and firsthand traveler blogs, rather than the prioritized subreddits. The Reddit-specific patterns should be validated in a short follow-up (e.g., via Reddit's own search/JSON endpoints).

Marketing vs. user voice. App-store listings and review aggregators mix vendor copy with genuine reviews; only reviewer-authored statements were treated as behavioral evidence. Vendor feature claims (e.g., "under 2 seconds," "170+ currencies") are reported as product positioning, not as verified user behavior.

A cited quantitative claim is vendor-sourced. One aggregator (thebobhotels.com) states, citing TravelSpend, that "travelers who stick to daily budgets spend 23% less than those who don't track their expenses." This is a company-supplied statistic without published methodology and should be treated as promotional, not independent — useful only as directional support for the value of daily-budget framing. [BOB](#)

[Hotels](#)

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Tool churn caveat. Trail Wallet, referenced repeatedly by travelers, was discontinued in November 2023; some blog references to it are dated. Its design lessons remain valid, but it is no longer a live competitor.

Secondary research only. These findings should be validated with primary interviews and usability testing before finalizing product requirements.